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THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

DOW JONES | News Corp ★★★★★ TUESDAY, OCTOBER 13, 2026 ~ VOL. CCLXXXVIII NO. 88 WSJ.com ★★★★ $5.00

DJIA 51850.55 ▲ 195.60 0.38% NASDAQ 27245.90 ▼ 0.4% STOXX 600 635.65 ▲ 0.6% 10-YR. TREAS. Closed (5.243%) OIL $93.74 ▲ $1.89 GOLD $4,165.80 ▼ $25.20 EURO $1.1157 YEN 158.63

What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **Major U.S. stock indexes** ended mixed, with the S&P 500 and Nasdaq losing 0.06% and 0.4%, respectively, and the Dow gaining 0.4%. The U.S. bond market was closed for the Columbus Day holiday. **A1**

◆ **Lawsuits are piling up** against Dodgers owner Mark Walter, brought by senior citizens who purchased annuities from his insurance companies. **B1**

◆ **A bitcoin-mining** business that appeared left for dead after the collapse of Sam Bankman-Fried's crypto empire is being resuscitated to serve the AI build-out. **B1**

◆ **Meta Platforms** released an AI model whose utility will be tested by how much it can improve retention and accelerate adoption of the company's Muse agent. **B3**

◆ **Quantum-computing** company IonQ struck an all-stock deal to buy closely held Elisity in a transaction that values the cybersecurity firm at up to $1.3 billion. **B5**

◆ **Dating-app company** Bumble is in advanced talks to be taken private in a deal that values it at roughly $1 billion. **B4**

◆ **Volkswagen's deliveries** fell in the third quarter as the German automaker continued to suffer from a deteriorating market in China. **B3**

◆ **China failed to report** a recovery in auto sales in September, traditionally the start of peak season. **B3**

◆ **In a legal filing**, supermarket chain Albertsons is demanding its top rival Kroger pay it at least $8 billion after their grocery megadeal imploded two years ago. **B1**

Worldwide

◆ **Iran is fortifying** its defenses, rallying loyalists and threatening a wider and harsher response against the U.S. and its Gulf allies as it prepares for potential American attacks after the midterm elections and seeks to deter them. **A1**

◆ **A suspected plot to** attack a U.S.-run military air base in England was "almost certainly" directed by Iran's Revolutionary Guard, British Prime Minister Andy Burnham said. **A6**

◆ **NATO's top military** commander sought to steady an anxious Europe by outlining the alliance's new plan to thwart a potential Russian assault along its eastern flank. **A8**

◆ **U.S. economists** Robert E. Hall and Michael Woodford were awarded the Nobel Prize for Economic Sciences for their work on the role of household and business expectations in providing the foundations of economic stability. **A2**

◆ **Ten megadonors** accounted for more than half of the $300 million that Trump raised for the new White House ballroom and legacy projects around Washington, a filing indicates. **A4**

◆ **Trump said** he is considering firing Kimberly Guilfoyle, his ambassador to Greece, after revelations that she asked a donor to cover personal expenses in the lead-up to her confirmation hearing. **A3**

◆ **British comedian** and actor Russell Brand appeared in a London court for the start of his trial on rape and sexual-assault charges. **A6**

◆ **Died: RJ Mitte**, 34, actor on "Breaking Bad." **A2**

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Federal Agents Search Congresswoman's Home



J. SCOTT APPLEWHITE/AP

RAID: Homeland Security Investigations officers carry boxes Monday from the Washington residence of Rep. Ilhan Omar (D-Minn.) during a search described as part of a criminal investigation. Omar's office called it 'an outrageous abuse of power.' A3

Options-Trading Frenzy Shows Bullish Investors' Zeal for Risk

Market's soaring volumes hit $700 billion a day—akin to meme-stock mania

By Krystal Hur And Hannah Erin Lang

Individual investors aren't letting anything get them down these days.

Their fervor is showing up in frenzied trading of options, or contracts that allow holders to buy or sell a stock at a set price, by a certain date. Volumes in options tied to individual stocks have recently reached levels seen during the meme-stock mania of 2021, about $700 billion of notional volume a day, according to Carrick Lane, an investment manager specializing in options strategies. The prices of call options, which give the right to buy, have eclipsed levels seen during that time.

A new generation of individual investors discovered the markets during the post-Covid rally, and by early 2021 many amateur traders were pushing into more complicated, and often riskier, bets. A boom in stock options and other derivatives was under way.

Those markets are now abuzz with retail activity once again, and Wall Street knows the reason: Individual investors are looking past rising interest rates, $100 oil prices and war in the Middle East. They are focusing on strong corporate earnings and are as comfortable rolling the dice on volatile markets as they were back when GameStop, Roaring Kitty and AMC Entertainment were the talk of Reddit forums.

Bullishness among individual investors, as measured by the percentage who expect stock prices to rise over the next six months, reached 40.3% for the week ended Oct. 7, according to the latest survey from the American Association of Individual Investors. That is the highest level since mid-July and comparable to levels seen in 2021.

Many, like 41-year-old Kunal Berry, are buoyed by the success of the artificial-intelligence trade and optimistic about the technology's poten-

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◆ **Heard on the Street: How to look at a narrow rally..... B10**

Iran Preps For More War Amid Trump's Threats

Regime, convinced the U.S. is ready to strike, rallies Iranians, fortifies nuclear sites

By Benoit Faucon

Iran is fortifying its defenses, rallying loyalists and threatening a wider, harsher response against the U.S. and its Gulf allies as it prepares for potential American attacks after the midterms and seeks to deter them.

Iranian officials have warned publicly and in private conversations with regional officials that the Islamic Republic will respond with further escalation across the Middle East if the U.S. launches new strikes.

Satellite images show Iran is strengthening sensitive locations, including nuclear sites and border areas, to make them more resilient to attacks. The government is also preparing Iranians for renewed war, sending paramilitary forces to read war stories to kindergartners, advertising training in firing shoulder-mounted antiaircraft missiles and holding rallies.

Iran has little ability to defend against attacks from advanced U.S. jets, high-altitude bombers or cruise missiles, giving it an incentive to try to deter such attacks with threats. The belligerent tone also serves as a distraction from the deepening economic misery Iranians are experiencing as the U.S. tightens sanctions and pressures airlines not to fly to the country, tightening the blockade.

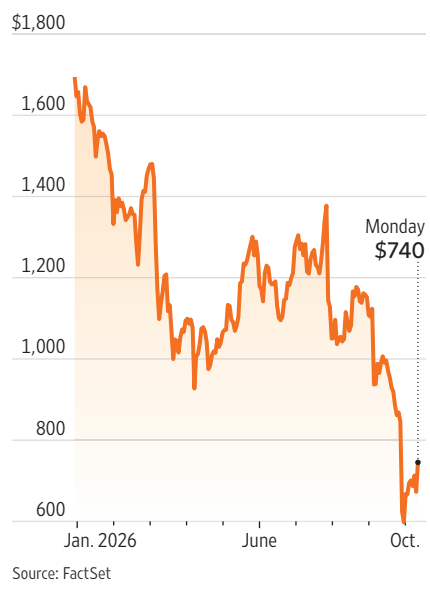
"The war footing is serving them well for now due to an impasse on many fronts—dip-

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FICO Hit By Rise Of Rival

FICO credit scores have long played a critical role in mortgage-underwriting decisions. Now regulators and lenders have opened the door to using a rival, VantageScore. The move to break Fair Isaac's hold over the mortgage market has sent its stock down about 60% this year. **B1**

Fair Isaac share price, year to date



Source: FactSet

Soaring Welfare Spending Is Crushing Britain

Disability benefit claims surge, but leaders struggle to make cuts

By Max Colchester and David Luhnow

LIVERPOOL, England—Catherine Wieland got on Britain's welfare rolls in 2021. With a history of emotional trauma, she was too anxious to go outside or carry out simple tasks like washing herself, she told the government.

Soon, she was receiving about £700, or $1,000, a month in disability benefits. And, it turns out, going outside quite a bit.

Using a taxpayer-subsidized program for those with disabilities, Wieland paid a small deposit for free use of a BMW, which she used to regularly visit the hair salon, dine out, attend a pride parade and visit an amusement park. According to court reports in her fraud conviction, she also flew to Cancún, Mexico.

Wieland's case is an extreme example of a new reality in the U.K.: Disability payouts are no longer just for those most in need; they've become a financial crutch for a swath of the population as wages stagnate and prices rise.

It's blowing up Britain's welfare bill, hamstringing its politicians and imperiling its long-term financial stability.

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First-Class Amenity Kits Are Now Holy Grail Collectibles

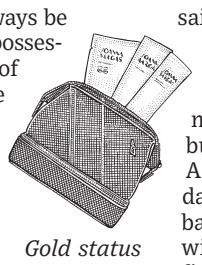
* * *

Travel enthusiasts accrue free toiletry pouches by the dozens; 'I love every single one'

By Victoria Albert

Like most New Yorkers, Andrew Lim doesn't have much space in his apartment.

The e-commerce specialist shares a tight one-bedroom with his husband in Manhattan. But there will always be room for one prized possession: His collection of about 200 airline amenity kits, the travel-sized toiletry pouches that come free with first- and business-class seats on long-haul flights.



Gold status

Lim, a travel content creator, has spent decades accumulating the kits. After flying more than 3 million miles, his collection includes rare finds like United Airlines' 'Star Wars' collaboration and newer offerings like China Airlines' partnership with Marc Jacobs.

He keeps them all tucked away in a closet—out of sight of his husband, who isn't as keen on the enterprise. But sometimes, he can't resist taking them out for a trip down memory lane.

"He thinks I'm crazy," said Lim, 51.

For most fliers, amenity kits are a quick fix for the annoyances of even business-class travel: A sleep mask to darken the cabin; lip balm and lotion to help with dry air; socks to find a little more comfort. But for the rare travel enthusiast, they are so much more: a way to memorialize a favorite trip or claim a piece of airline history.

Devotees collect them by the dozens, even hundreds. They show them off alongside

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INSIDE



PERSONAL JOURNAL
Is your grown child pulling away? Look for the early signs of estrangement. **A11**



ZUMA PRESS

BUSINESS & FINANCE
Tom Cruise was going after a best actor Oscar. Then 'Digger' flopped. **B1**

Hope Swells in Venezuela For Oil Industry's Revival

By Kejal Vyas

CABIMAS, Venezuela—An oil gusher discovered more than 100 years ago gave birth to Venezuela's energy industry near this once-booming city on the shores of Lake Maracaibo. Today, Cabimas is at the center of the U.S. effort to resurrect the sector.

This city of 350,000 resembles an oil-industry graveyard. Mangled drill towers and collapsing offshore platforms are visible as far as the eye can see. Hardened globs of crude cling to fishing nets pulled from the lake, and natural gas gurgles up from busted underwater pipelines. The lake's shores are black with petroleum.

Nearby, children play baseball between leaky pump jacks that often stop working because of power outages that last up to 12 hours a day.

Many residents here said they can't wait for U.S. investors to arrive and start plowing money into rebuilding the country's dilapidated oil infrastructure. Many remember the boom years when oil workers enjoyed housing provided by international oil companies, along with neighborhoods with swimming pools, sports clubs and golf courses, and a lake with clean water and healthy marine life.

The question they are asking is: Can the U.S. bring the good times back?

"God willing, the foreigners will come back soon and we'll have a better quality of life," said José Medina, a fisherman with five children. But he is worried it will take a long time. "It feels like we're neither moving forward nor backward."

The decaying industry here reflects two decades of mismanagement under late President Hugo Chávez and his successor Nicolás Maduro, whom the U.S. captured in a raid in January and is prosecuting in New York on drug-trafficking charges, which Maduro denies. Industry executives and experts said residents' fears are well-founded: Reviving Vene-

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